

THE CHAIN OF DETERMINATION FROM ABSTRACT LABOUR TO MARKET PRICE: A CATEGORICAL EXPOSITION

INTRODUCTION: THE ARCHITECTURE OF THE ARGUMENT

The chain of determination from abstract labour to market price constitutes the central logical architecture of Marx's critique of political economy. It proceeds from the most abstract category—the common social substance of commodities—through a series of increasingly concrete determinations, arriving finally at the actual market price at which a commodity changes hands on a given day. Each categorical transition is logically necessary: the preceding determination proves insufficient to account for the real movement of capitalist production, and a new, more concrete determination is required to resolve the insufficiency.

This exposition reconstructs the chain as a categorical progression operating across three analytically distinct levels: the essential determination of value (capital in general), the phenomenal expression of value (the value-form and money), and the distributional modification of value (many capitals, competition, prices of production). The full chain was never presented in a single unified text. It is distributed across manuscripts spanning 1857–1894, from the Grundrisse through A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy, Theories of Surplus Value, Value, Price and Profit, and the three volumes of Capital—the latter two compiled by Engels from disorderly manuscripts. The reconstruction that follows preserves the logical order of categories even where this departs from the chronological order of composition, and flags genuine tensions within the corpus rather than papering over them.

I. ABSTRACT LABOUR: THE SUBSTANCE OF VALUE

The logical starting point is the commodity—the elementary form of wealth in societies where the capitalist mode of production prevails. Every commodity presents itself as a unity of use-value and exchange-value. The question is: what makes qualitatively different products commensurable as exchangeables? Marx's answer is that all commodity-producing labour possesses a twofold character. As concrete useful labour, it produces specific use-values—weaving produces linen, tailoring produces coats. But as abstract human labour, it creates value: "Productive activity, if we leave out of sight its special form, viz., the useful character of the labour, is nothing but the expenditure of human labour power. Tailoring and weaving, though qualitatively different productive activities, are each a productive expenditure of human brains, nerves, and muscles, and in this sense are human labour" (Marx, 1867). Marx identifies this dual character as "the pivot on which a clear comprehension of political economy turns" (Marx, 1867).

In Value, Price and Profit (1865), the same determination is stated from the side of exchange: "As the exchangeable values of commodities are only social functions of those things, and have nothing at all to do with their natural qualities, we must first ask, What

is the common social substance of all commodities? It is Labour. To produce a commodity a certain amount of labour must be bestowed upon it, or worked up in it. And I say not only Labour, but social Labour" (Marx, 1865).

An unresolved tension must be flagged here. The nature of abstract labour is genuinely ambiguous within the corpus. In Capital Vol. I, Marx describes it as a matter of physiology—"an expenditure of human labour power" in the sense of "human brains, nerves, and muscles" (Marx, 1867). But in A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy (1859), abstract labour appears as a category constituted through exchange itself: "the different kinds of individual labour represented in these particular use values, in fact, become labour in general, and in this way social labour, only by actually being exchanged for one another" (Marx, 1859). The corpus supports both a physiological and a purely social reading; the two are not synthetically resolved by Marx himself.

A further gap: the reduction of complex to simple labour—how skilled labour counts as a multiple of unskilled labour—is asserted rather than fully derived. Marx states that "Experience shows that this reduction is constantly being made" (Marx, 1867) and that "The laws governing this reduction do not concern us here" (Marx, 1859). The mechanism of this reduction remains an acknowledged incompleteness.

II. SOCIALLY NECESSARY LABOUR-TIME: THE MEASURE OF VALUE-MAGNITUDE

Abstract labour provides the substance of value; its magnitude requires a further determination. Why is this transition necessary? Because abstract labour as such is qualitative—a common social substance. But exchange demands quantitative commensuration: how much of one commodity for how much of another? The answer is that the magnitude of value is determined by socially necessary labour-time—"that required to produce an article under the normal conditions of production, and with the average degree of skill and intensity prevalent at the time" (Marx, 1867).

Without this qualification, individual labour-time would determine value, and "the more idle and unskilful the labourer, the more valuable would his commodity be" (Marx, 1867)—an obvious absurdity. The social character of value demands that only labour validated as average social labour counts. Marx illustrates this with the hand-loom weaver displaced by the power-loom: "The poor hand-loom weaver now worked seventeen or eighteen hours daily, instead of the nine or ten hours he had worked before. Still the product of twenty hours of his labour represented now only ten social hours of labour" (Marx, 1865).

In The Poverty of Philosophy (1847), the same principle is rendered even more sharply: "what determines value is not the time taken to produce a thing, but the minimum time it could possibly be produced in, and this minimum is ascertained by competition" (Marx, 1847). By the Grundrisse (1857–58), this is reformulated as a "basic law developed under competition": "value is determined, not by the labour contained in it, or by the labour time in which it is produced, but by the labour time in which it can be produced, or by the labour time necessary for reproduction" (Marx, 1858).

A note on the two senses of "socially necessary labour-time": The present step concerns primarily the first sense—the technical-average production time under normal conditions. A second sense—the social validation that private labour counts as social labour through exchange—becomes operative at later stages of the exposition, particularly in the determination of market value (Section IX below). The research guidelines correctly flag this ambiguity; the two senses must not be conflated.

III. VALUE AS THE SOCIAL SUBSTANCE OF COMMODITIES

Why is a further step needed? Because the previous two determinations—abstract labour as substance, socially necessary labour-time as measure—establish value only analytically, as a property of labour. Value must now be identified as a property of the commodity itself: a crystal of objectified social labour-time, the immaterial social relation that constitutes the common substance of all commodities as exchangeables. In the Contribution, Marx writes: "Labour time is the living state of existence of labour, irrespective of its form, its content and its individual features... The labour time objectified in the use values of commodities is both the substance that turns them into exchange values and therefore into commodities, and the standard by which the precise magnitude of their value is measured" (Marx, 1859).

The crucial distinction established here is threefold: **value** (the immaterial social relation), **exchange-value** (its phenomenal form in exchange), and **use-value** (the qualitative, material side of the commodity). In early texts, Marx sometimes uses "value" and "exchange-value" interchangeably; by Capital Vol. I, the distinction is systematic. Value is the social substance; exchange-value is "the form of appearance of value" (Marx, 1867). Collapsing them, Marx insists, reproduces the central error of classical political economy.

But value so determined is still a silent, invisible property. It has no independent existence in the body of the commodity that possesses it. How, then, does it manifest? This insufficiency drives the exposition to the next determination.

IV. THE VALUE-FORM: FROM SIMPLE EXPRESSION TO THE MONEY-FORM

Value cannot appear directly in the body of the commodity that possesses it. It can only appear in the body of another commodity. This structural constraint generates the analysis of the value-form, which Marx calls the key to the whole theory: "The whole mystery of the form of value lies hidden in this elementary form" (Marx, 1867). The analysis proceeds through four logically necessary stages:

(A) The Elementary or Accidental Form of Value: 20 yards of linen = 1 coat. The linen (the commodity in relative form) expresses its value in the natural form of the coat (the equivalent). The coat's use-value serves as the mirror of the linen's value. But this form is deficient: the value expression is accidental, limited to a single relation.

(B) The Total or Expanded Form: 20 yards of linen = 1 coat = 10 lbs tea = 40 lbs coffee = ... The deficiency of form A is overcome by expressing value in an indefinite series of equivalents. This "for the first time" shows value "in its true light as a congelation of undifferentiated human labour" (Marx, 1867). But the expanded form is itself deficient: the series is endless and incomplete, and each commodity has a different expanded expression.

(C) The General Form of Value: The deficiency of form B is overcome by inverting it: all commodities now express their value in a single, excluded commodity—the universal equivalent. "The general form of value, C, results from the joint action of the whole world of commodities, and from that alone" (Marx, 1867). Value now has a unified, socially recognizable expression.

(D) The Money-Form: The universal equivalent becomes socially fixed in one particular commodity—historically, gold. "Gold is in form D, what linen was in form C — the universal equivalent. The progress consists in this alone, that the character of direct and universal

exchangeability... has now, by social custom, become finally identified with the substance, gold" (Marx, 1867).

The significance of this derivation is that money is not an arbitrary convention or technical convenience but a logically necessary outcome of the commodity form itself. As the Contribution states: "A social relation of production appears as something existing apart from individual human beings... it is this perverted appearance, this prosaically real, and by no means imaginary, mystification that is characteristic of all social forms of labour positing exchange value" (Marx, 1859). This is commodity fetishism at its root: the social relation of value appears as a natural property of the money-thing.

V. PRICE AS THE MONEY-NAME OF VALUE

With money established as the universal equivalent, the value of any commodity can be expressed as a quantity of money—its price. In *Value, Price and Profit*, Marx states: "Price, taken by itself, is nothing but the monetary expression of value... Looking somewhat closer into the monetary expression of value, or what comes to the same, the conversion of value into price, you will find that it is a process by which you give to the values of all commodities an independent and homogeneous form, or by which you express them as quantities of equal social labour. So far as it is but the monetary expression of value, price has been called natural price by Adam Smith, 'prix nécessaire' by the French physiocrats" (Marx, 1865). In *Capital Vol. I*, price is "the money name of the labour realised in a commodity" (Marx, 1867).

But a crucial structural feature emerges at this very point. The price-form, by its nature, already allows for quantitative divergence between price and value:

"The possibility, therefore, of quantitative incongruity between price and magnitude of value, or the deviation of the former from the latter, is inherent in the price form itself. This is no defect, but, on the contrary, admirably adapts the price form to a mode of production whose inherent laws impose themselves only as the mean of apparently lawless irregularities that compensate one another." (Marx, 1867)

This is a determination of the highest importance: before any consideration of profit, competition, or supply and demand, the price-form as such contains the structural possibility that price $\neq$ value. The divergences that later emerge at the level of prices of production and market prices are not anomalies grafted onto an otherwise harmonious system but are inscribed in the price-form from the outset.

The exposition has now arrived at value expressed as price—the "natural price" or regulating centre. But it remains at the level of simple circulation, where commodities exchange at their values. To proceed further requires a transition from the analysis of form (how value appears) to the analysis of content (how surplus value is produced). This transition presupposes a decisive historical condition: that labour-power has itself become a commodity (Marx, 1863).

VI. SURPLUS VALUE: THE SUBSTANCE OF CAPITALIST PROFIT

The transition from simple commodity circulation to capitalist production introduces a new determination that cannot be derived from the commodity form alone. What the worker sells to the capitalist is not "labour" but labour-power—the capacity to work. This distinction, absent in classical political economy and in Marx's own early writings (where "price of

labour" is used loosely), is the foundation of the theory of surplus value. "The value of the labouring power is determined by the quantity of labour necessary to maintain or reproduce it, but the use of that labouring power is only limited by the active energies and physical strength of the labourer. The daily or weekly value of the labouring power is quite distinct from the daily or weekly exercise of that power" (Marx, 1865).

Surplus value is the difference between the value produced by the worker during the working day and the value of the worker's labour-power. It arises in production, not in exchange: "The capitalist would consequently realise the profit of three shillings, not by selling his commodity at a price over and above its value, but by selling it at its real value" (Marx, 1865). In Capital Vol. I, the rate of surplus value (s/v) is "an exact expression for the degree of exploitation of labour power by capital" (Marx, 1867).

Why is this determination necessary for the chain? Without surplus value, the passage from value to profit is unintelligible. Surplus value is the real content of which profit—and all its derivative forms (interest, rent, commercial profit)—is the mystified phenomenal expression.

VII. THE FORMAL CONVERSION OF SURPLUS VALUE INTO PROFIT

Surplus value, however, does not appear as surplus value to the individual capitalist. It appears as profit—surplus value measured not against variable capital alone but against the total capital advanced. This is not merely a change of denominator but a real mystification: all parts of capital now appear equally as the basis of valorization, and the specific role of living labour in creating new value is obliterated.

The Grundrisse states this with particular force: "Surplus value expressed as profit always appears as a smaller proportion than that actually constituted by surplus value in its immediate reality. For instead of being measured in relation to a part of the capital, that exchanged for living labour... it is measured in relation to the total" (Marx, 1858). And: "The transformation of surplus value into the form of profit, this method of calculation of surplus value by capital, much as it is based on an illusion as to the nature of surplus value, or rather disguises it, is necessary from the standpoint of capital" (Marx, 1858).

The 1861–63 manuscripts underscore the conceptual (not merely numerical) character of this transformation: "The difference is not only numerical but also conceptual, essential... Surplus value obtains a form in which the secret of its origin is no longer hinted at with the slightest trace" (Marx, 1863). This is an objective mystification—a structural feature of the capital relation, not a subjective error of accounting. It is, moreover, the form in which surplus value actually operates: "The relation of surplus value as a relation of profit dominates bourgeois production, determines the distribution of the capitals in the different branches of production" (Marx, 1863).

But the category of profit, though necessary, immediately generates a new problem that drives the exposition forward.

VIII. UNEQUAL ORGANIC COMPOSITIONS AND THE PROBLEM OF UNEQUAL PROFIT RATES

The transition from "capital in general" to "many capitals" introduces the organic composition of capital—the ratio of constant capital (c , means of production) to variable capital (v , labour-power). Different branches of production have different organic

compositions. Since surplus value is produced only by variable capital, equal-sized capitals with different compositions produce different amounts of surplus value and therefore yield different rates of profit—if commodities are sold at their values.

The 1861–63 manuscripts demonstrate this with numerical precision: "if the commodities were sold at their values or if the average prices of the commodities were equal to their values, then the rate of profit in the various spheres would have to vary a great deal. In one case it would be 50, in others 40, 30, 20, 10, etc." (Marx, 1863). A worked example: "If the capital a.=80c+20v, then the value of the product=110 and the profit=10... If the capital b.=40c+60v, then the value of the product=130, and the profit=30... If the capital c=60c+40v, then the value of the product=120 and the profit=20%" (Marx, 1863).

This situation—equal capitals earning vastly different returns simply because of their technical composition—is unsustainable under conditions of free competition. Capital is mobile and seeks the highest return. The inequality of profit rates is therefore not a resting point but a driving contradiction that demands resolution.

IX. THE GENERAL RATE OF PROFIT AND PRICES OF PRODUCTION: THE TRANSFORMATION OF VALUES

Competition among capitals—their tendency to migrate from branches with lower profit rates to those with higher ones—tendentially equalizes the rate of profit across branches. The result is a general or average rate of profit, calculated as total surplus value divided by total social capital. Each capital then earns this average profit regardless of the surplus value it directly produces. The **price of production** of a commodity equals its cost-price ($c + v$ consumed) plus the average profit on the capital advanced.

Marx's earliest rigorous formulation of this mechanism appears in the Grundrisse: "The inequality of profit in different branches of industry for capitals of the same size, i.e. the inequality of the rate of profit, is a condition and presupposition for the equalisations brought about by competition" (Marx, 1858). The 1861–63 manuscripts demonstrate the result numerically:

"Thus the 3 capitals = 300 yield a total profit = $10 + 30 + 20 = 60$, and this makes an average of 20% for 100. This average profit is made by each of the capitals if it sells the commodity it produces at £120. The capital a: 80c+20v, sells at £10 above its value; capital b: 40c+60v, sells at £10 below its value; capital c: 60c+40v sells at its value. All the commodities taken together, are sold at their value: $120+120+120=£360$. In fact the value of $a+b+c = 110+130+120 = £360$." (Marx, 1863)

The social division of surplus value described here means that "Each capital, therefore, in each particular trade, represents a portion of a total capital of the same organic composition... As such a portion, it draws its dividends from the surplus value created by the aggregate capital, in accordance with its size" (Marx, 1863). Individual prices of production diverge from individual values, but the aggregate constraint holds: total prices of production equal total values, and total profit equals total surplus value. "The sum total of these cost prices of all the commodities taken together will be equal to their value. Similarly the total profit will be=to the total surplus value" (Marx, 1863).

Marx states the logical necessity of this transformation with complete explicitness: "the emergence, realisation, creation of the general rate of profit necessitates the transformation of values into cost prices that are different from these values" (Marx, 1863).

Merchant's capital participates in this equalization without producing surplus value, thereby lowering the general rate below what industrial capital alone would yield: "if it were not that 1/10 of the total capital was merchant's capital and the general rate of profit thereby lowered by 1/10" (Marx, 1894). Similarly, the rate of interest is bounded by the average rate of profit: "the average rate of profit is to be regarded as the ultimate determinant of the maximum limit of interest" (Marx, 1894).

The transformation problem must be flagged as an unresolved tension. Marx's procedure transforms the outputs into prices of production but leaves the inputs (cost-price components) still calculated at values rather than at prices of production. Marx himself acknowledges the need for "further correction" (Marx, 1863) but does not carry it out systematically. The 1861-63 manuscripts show him repeatedly wrestling with this issue in the context of Ricardo's failure to distinguish values from cost-prices (Marx, 1863). Whether this constitutes an error in principle or merely an incomplete procedure—a deliberate methodological abstraction versus a genuine theoretical gap—is unresolved in the manuscripts.

An important corollary: "All changes in the production price of commodities are reducible to changes in value; but not all changes in the value of commodities necessarily express themselves in the change of the production price" (Marx, 1863). The law of value remains operative; prices of production are the form in which it operates under conditions of many competing capitals.

X. MARKET VALUE: INTRA-BRANCH REGULATION

The previous step established prices of production as the inter-branch centres of gravity, determined through the equalization of profit rates across different spheres of production. But within a single branch, individual producers operate under different conditions—different productivity, different costs, different individual values. A new determination is therefore required: how is a single regulating price established within a branch?

This is the category of **market value**. As Marx explains in *Value, Price and Profit*: "You all know that the market price is the same for all commodities of the same kind, however the conditions of production may differ for the individual producers. The market price expresses only the average amount of social labour necessary, under the average conditions of production, to supply the market with a certain mass of a certain article. It is calculated upon the whole lot of a commodity of a certain description" (Marx, 1865).

In the 1861-63 manuscripts, this is formulated with greater precision: "the value of each individual commodity in a particular sphere of production is determined by the total mass of social labour time required by the total mass of the commodities of this particular sphere of social production and not by the individual values of the separate commodities" (Marx, 1863). Competition within the branch "equalises the different individual values to the same, equal, undifferentiated market value, by permitting differences between individual profits" (Marx, 1863).

The key distinction between the two operations of competition is stated explicitly: "The first law applies to the various independent capitals invested in the same sphere of production. The second applies to capitals in so far as they are invested in different spheres of production" (Marx, 1863). Market value is thus the intra-branch counterpart to prices of production as the inter-branch regulator.

A complication arises in agriculture and extractive industries, where landed property can prevent surplus value from entering the general equalization, generating absolute rent above differential rent. The 1861-63 manuscripts develop this extensively (Marx, 1863),

(Marx, 1863), showing that agricultural products may sell at their value rather than at their price of production—a genuine modification of the chain that prevents any simple, universal identification of the centre of gravity with the price of production.

XI. MARKET PRICE: THE FINAL PHENOMENAL FORM

The exposition has now established two regulating centres: prices of production (inter-branch) and market value (intra-branch). But neither of these is the actual price at which commodities are sold. The actual market price fluctuates around these centres under the influence of supply and demand. This is the most concrete determination in the chain—the one that integrates all prior categories.

Marx states the relationship clearly:

"The oscillations of market prices, rising now over, sinking now under the value or natural price, depend upon the fluctuations of supply and demand... If supply and demand equilibrate each other, the market prices of commodities will correspond to their natural prices, that is to say, to their values, as determined by the respective quantities of labour required for their production. But supply and demand must constantly tend to equilibrate each other, although they do so only by compensating one fluctuation by another, a rise by a fall, and vice versa." (Marx, 1865)

And: "Considering the whole cycle, you will find that one deviation of the market price is being compensated by the other, and that, taking the average of the cycle, the market prices of commodities are regulated by their values" (Marx, 1865). From the 1861–63 manuscripts: "The actual market price is now above, now below this market value and coincides with it only by chance. Over a certain period, however, the fluctuations equal each other out and it can be said that the average of the actual market prices is the market price which represents the market value" (Marx, 1863).

The decisive point is that supply and demand explain the deviations but not the centre itself. When supply and demand balance, they cease to explain anything, and the price must be accounted for by the deeper determination. Ricardo, cited by Marx in *The Poverty of Philosophy*, stated this clearly: "It is the cost of production which must ultimately regulate the price of commodities, and not, as has been often said, the proportion between supply and demand" (Marx, 1847).

The market price at which a commodity is sold on a given day thus contains within itself, in condensed and inverted form, the entire chain from abstract labour through socially necessary labour-time, value, surplus value, profit, prices of production, and market value. As Marx observes: "What value is for the genuine economist the market price is for the practical capitalist, that is, in each case the primary factor of the whole movement" (Marx, 1863).

XII. COMPETITION AS THE MECHANISM OF ENFORCEMENT THROUGH APPARENT INVERSION

A final categorical determination must be stated: the role of competition as the mechanism that enforces the law of value precisely by appearing to negate it. Competition is not an

independent explanatory principle but the mode of execution of the immanent laws of capital. The Grundrisse is the most explicit text on this point:

"Competition executes the inner laws of capital; it turns them into coercive laws in relation to the individual capital, but it does not invent them. It realises them. To wish to explain them simply by competition means to admit that one does not understand them." (Marx, 1858)

"To impose the immanent laws of capital upon it as an external necessity, competition apparently completely inverts all of them, distorts them." (Marx, 1858)

"What is inherent in the nature of capital is actually externalised, as an outward necessity, only by competition, which is merely the forcing by the many capitals of the immanent determinations of capital upon one another and upon themselves. Hence not a single category of the bourgeois economy, not even the most basic one, e.g. the determination of value, really comes into its own [other than] through free competition." (Marx, 1858)

This methodological insight governs the entire chain from Section VIII onward. Competition operates at two distinct levels: within branches, it establishes market value by enforcing the socially necessary labour-time determination against individual divergences; between branches, it equalizes profit rates and transforms values into prices of production. In both cases, what appears on the surface—the chaotic movement of prices, the migration of capitals, the oscillation of supply and demand—is the necessary phenomenal form through which the inner determination (value as objectified abstract labour) asserts itself.

The consequence is that the law of value is not abrogated by prices of production—it operates through them. Individual prices diverge from individual values, but total prices equal total values; total profit equals total surplus value. The "apparently lawless irregularities" of market prices are not violations of the law but the very mode of its operation, as the price-form itself already indicated (Marx, 1867).

CONCLUSION: THE CONDENSED CHAIN AND ITS OPEN QUESTIONS

The complete chain of determination runs as follows, with each step logically presupposing its predecessor:

Abstract Labour (substance of value) → **Socially Necessary Labour-Time** (magnitude of value) → **Value** (objectified social labour as property of the commodity) → **Value-Form** → **Money** (phenomenal expression through the universal equivalent) → **Price** (money-name of value; structural possibility of divergence) → **Surplus Value** (value produced beyond the value of labour-power) → **Profit** (surplus value measured against total capital; objective mystification) → **Unequal Profit Rates** (consequence of different organic compositions) → **Prices of Production** (cost-price + average profit; inter-branch equalization) → **Market Value** (intra-branch averaging) → **Market Price** (actual price oscillating around the regulating centre).

Competition is the mechanism that operates at every stage from the formation of the general rate of profit onward, enforcing the law of value through its apparent inversion.

Several questions remain genuinely open within the corpus and must not be presented as resolved:

1. **The nature of abstract labour**—physiological or purely social—is textually ambiguous and supports rival interpretations.

2. **The transformation problem**—whether the failure to transform inputs constitutes an incompleteness in principle or merely an unfinished procedure—is unresolved in the manuscripts.
3. **Rent as a modification of the chain**—landed property can prevent full equalization, so that agricultural prices may be regulated by value rather than price of production.
4. **Turnover time**—the effect of circulation time on the effective rate of profit is developed in the Grundrisse (Marx, 1858) but not fully integrated into the prices-of-production framework.
5. **Credit, crises, and the world market**—Marx intended these as further concretizations but never completed them. The Grundrisse indicates that "exchange does not alter the inner conditions of valorisation, but it projects them outwards, gives them a form independent of one another" (Marx, 1858), but the systematic development of these categories was left unfinished.

The actual market price at a given moment—the most concrete determination—thus carries within itself the entire chain of abstract determinations, from the social substance of value through every form-transformation and distributional modification. To explain it adequately requires traversing the whole path; to invoke supply and demand alone is, as Marx insists, to confess that one does not understand the laws one claims to explain.

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